

Existence of God: the teleological argument



William Blake's *The Ancient of Days* depicts God as an all-powerful architect of the universe.

A recurrent concern for medieval Christianity was whether there could be a philosophical, rational proof of God's existence. While many in the Church believed this to be simply a matter of faith, the incorporation of philosophy into religion encouraged rational justification. Several arguments for God's existence were put forward, including the so-called argument of design, or teleological argument (from the Greek *telos*, purpose). The reasoning goes that if we look at the world around us, we see evidence of order. Everything

looks as if it has been designed for a purpose, and if everything has been designed, then there must have been a designer – God. The argument, developed from ideas in Plato and Aristotle, appears not only in Christian philosophers such as Augustine and Thomas Aquinas, but also in the work of the Islamic philosopher Averroes (see [Averroes](#)). Later philosophers challenged this, questioning the notion of purpose and replacing it with cause, while scientific advances, in particular the theory of evolution, have helped to refute the argument.